

FGCT5017 Tools and Production - Harry Dillamore - 2402521

Question

**What recent games, media and franchises have informed the development of your practical portfolio?
How might these points of inspiration be critically explored and contextualised using academic knowledge and insights into your creative practice?**

Essay

Introduction

In this unit I have worked on the game 'Greedy Piggies' which is a multiplayer card game developed in Unreal Engine 5 (2026), where players are anthropomorphic pigs who are trying to earn the most money by lying and bluffing their way through the game. It is set in an expensive high rise building where the characters are sat around a table playing the card game. The players are able to purchase cards from a shop using the money they earn in the game to try and get an advantage over the others.

My essay focuses on how different media have influenced my work on the game 'Greedy Piggies'. It will cover key concepts from the course such as money games, Nature in games, and procedural rhetoric.

Literature review

Nature in Games - Thoreau (1854), Orwell (1945)

Nature in media is often presented as a *pastoral fantasy* where the 'wild' is seen as pure and untainted by humanity and urban culture. This can be used in games to create a sense of freedom and escape from the patterns of modern life. Thoreau describes nature as a place where one can 'live deliberately' as it is away from the corrupting influences in modern society. In Greedy Piggies, we have created a world which demonstrates these dangerous effects of money and capitalism. Here the characters subvert the idea of pastoral fantasy by being typically 'natural' creatures who have been removed from the natural world and have become immoral, greedy creatures who are willing to do anything to get rich. This is emphasising the idea that putting people in a system where money is the primary motivator can lead to them losing their natural selves. Thoreau talks about this binary between the natural world and the urban world where nature is the only place that is free of the moral degradation of society. The game explores this idea by showing how, without this escape, even the most natural creatures can become corrupted by greed.

In George Orwell's 'Animal Farm' we see a similar idea explored where the animals take on the roles of humans and this leads to them becoming corrupt and power hungry. Even the well intentioned 'revolution' of the animals leads to them becoming the new oppressors of the other animals. In the final scene of the book, the pigs are no longer able to be distinguished from the humans they overthrew. They are depicted sat around a table playing cards with the humans, just as the pigs in our game do. In our game we were influenced by Orwell's depiction of the pigs in the final scene, showing pigs who have become so motivated by money and greed and are in the most unnatural environment imaginable. Demonstrating how the chase for power continues forever, even now that they have made it to the 'top' represented by them being in the

penthouse of the building - they are still hungry for more and willing to lie and deceive, and trick each other out of their money. The game also uses a 'bankruptcy' system, where players who enter negative scores have heavier and heavier penalties applied to them, making it harder for them to recover. This encourages players to target the weak and punish them for their failures, creating a ruthless environment where the strong prey on the weak. This is a reflection of the real world capitalist system where the rich get richer and the poor get poorer.

Procedural Rhetoric - Bogost (2007)

In *Persuasive Games* Ian Bogost argues that the true 'persuasive power' of a game comes from the rules and systems that a game is made up of, and the way that the player must experience and understand these systems while they play the game. This is unique compared to traditional media where points are made verbally or visually; in games they are made 'procedurally'. Bogost states that this is a more powerful method of communication because 'they engage the player in a performance of the logic of that message.' (Bogost, 2007). His point is that if players have to understand the systems and rules of a game in order to play it, then they will have to engage more deeply with the message of the media. In *Greedy Piggies*, the procedural rhetoric is used to demonstrate the lack of morals and corrupting nature of money and capitalism. This is because being successful in the game requires the player to engage in deceitful and manipulative behaviour. This is done through the auditing system, where players must decide whether to trust what the other players have declared. With high stakes attached to auditing, the system creates tension and mistrust. Meaning that rather than telling the players the world is corrupt, it forces them to use deceitful and manipulative behaviour in order to win the game.

Money Games - Dyer-Witheford and de Peuter (2009), Evans (2016)

In *Games of Empire: Global Capitalism and Video Games* Nick Dyer-Witheford and Greig de Peuter discuss how video games have become the 'ideal medium' for global capitalism. They argue that games train players for capitalism because they create an environment where every action has a quantifiable value, and players strive to maximise their score. They say that games are reinforcing the beliefs and values of capitalism, such as competition, where for one person to win, another must lose.

Evans describes the impatience economy as something which aims to create enough artificial friction for players to feel it is worth it to pay for a solution (Evans, 2016). Such as to skip wait times, or get more lives, ect. Dyer-Witheford and de Peuter argue that the real 'product' in the impatience economy is the *training* of the players to accept that - even if they do not pay for the solution - money can be used to get ahead of others. In *Greedy Piggies*, we do not want to literally train players to be greedy, so the entire game is free of any microtransactions or paywalls. But we do want them to have an experience which highlights these points and explore the idea of how money can be used to gain advantage and get ahead of others. This is done through systems like the shop cards which allow players who can afford to to buy cards that will help them or allow them to punish other players, and push them into bankruptcy - and ultimately out of the game.

Case Studies

Papers, Please - Lucas Pope (2013)

Papers, Please (Lucas Pope, 2013) is an example of a game which explores the concept of procedural rhetoric. It does this by giving the player the role of a border control officer in a fictional country called Arstotzka. The player must take an active role in the process of checking the passports and deciding who will be allowed in

the country and who won't. Often choosing between making the morally correct decision, like letting in a family who need help, and the decision which will benefit them most financially, by adhering to the strict rules of the state. The game pressures the player to make quick and accurate decisions in order to earn money that they need to survive. By implementing a *process* of difficult decision making and moral dilemmas under pressure, the game makes a much stronger point and is able to have a more powerful impact on the player than if it were to simply describe the situation to them. It makes the player question whether they are making the correct decisions or becoming a part of an oppressive system. I found that when I played this game, it made me think about the real world systems similar to this and I felt I had a better understanding of how people become unwilling participants in cruelty. Showing the power of procedural rhetoric to make players think about the message of media on a deeper level.

Balatro - LocalThunk (2024)

Balatro (LocalThunk, 2024) is a roguelike game based on poker that became widely successful and critically acclaimed upon its release. It has a very simple but addictive gameplay loop, where the player must make poker hands that meet a certain point threshold to progress to the next round. This leads to the player constantly trying to optimise their play for the highest score possible. Chasing an exponentially increasing score threshold, and making choices on whether to play it safe and make small points, or take a risk and try and make a big score. This mirrors the real world idea of chasing more and more money and power, and the risks people will take in order to get it - as discussed by Dyer-Witthford and de Peuter (2009) - it makes the player accustomed to this way of thinking.

Balatro is able to maintain an ethical stance on this subject because it is an example of a for profit game (poker) being de-commodified by taking away the aspect of real money. It also exposes the scoring system to the user so that they can try to 'break' it rather than be controlled by it. This is something that we kept in mind when designing Greedy Piggies. As we want to critique the corrupting nature of money and capitalism, without accidentally feeding into it.

Greedy Piggies

With Greedy Piggies, we have crafted a games which explores the corrupting nature of a capitalist society, through using common 'money game' tropes and mechanics - but without any actual money involved and in such a way that the dark side of these mechanics are highlighted. We do this with the core gameplay loop, which demonstrates procedural rhetoric in action. By forcing the players to use unethical strategies to have the best chance of winning the game, such as targeting weaker players to remove them from the game. This is aimed to make players feel guilt, particularly when they are playing with friends who they have to betray and lie to in order to win. These mechanics in combination with the representation of pigs, which are natural creatures becoming cruel and greedy once placed into an economic system, is intended to make the players question the similar systems in the real world and the effect it has on people.

Conclusion

This essay looks at how Greedy Piggies explores different themes and concepts on how messages can be conveyed through games. It explains how the game communicates a warning about the potential corruption caused by capitalism and greed. It does this through the use of: nature, procedural rhetoric, and money to critique systems common in real life and in many games. The essay shows how these elements are often used in games and how they can be used to create a powerful message that many players will not understand on a conscious level but will take in to some degree.

Research Process

I looked at the writing of Thoreau because I found that his ideas about nature being the only place where people can be truly free and happy, and that society is corrupting, were very relevant to this game where animals have been removed from nature and corrupted by urban society. I chose to make this a focus because I felt it was a strong foundation from which I could explain the game's themes, using George Orwell's *Animal Farm* as a familiar comparison point. I looked at procedural rhetoric and Bogost's ideas on how games can convey stronger messages than other media through procedures and systems because *Greedy Piggies* demands that the player fully take on the role of lying and betraying friends in order to win. I felt this was a particularly important concept after having played *Papers, Please* and feeling the impact of the procedural rhetoric first hand. The work of Dyer-witheford and de Peuter as well as Evans, on the concept of money games showed how games can be used to both feed into and critique capitalist systems, understanding these patterns seen in games, allowed me to create work which is a satirical take on these systems. Without imitating the features like microtransactions which are often the parts that make games feel unethical.

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